

LAPTOPS

Like most other categories, notebooks experienced serious price drops last year. A few months after our notebook test, we were surprised to see the specifications of notebooks from major players like Dell and HP being upped—instead of dropping prices, we were seeing better CPUs, more memory, and bigger drives on identically-priced models. We also saw the introduction of the latest series of DX10 graphics chipsets into the latest models. For Windows Vista, 2 GB of RAM is considered mandatory, and it's good to see vendors giving us more memory, considering that was our number one gripe with most of the 1 GB laptops anyways.

PERFORMANCE LAPTOPS

The Reigning Champion HP DV6226tx

Our winner, the HP DV6226tx, was a winning combination of on-paper specs, features, ergonomics, style, and functionality. A Core 2 Duo processor (T5200) and 1 GB of memory, a GeForce 7400GO graphics solution, and inbuilt speakers by Altec Lansing meant the DV6226tx was an attractive bundle. At Rs 56,990, it wasn't pricey either—Gold belonged here.

The Contender Dell XPS 1530

Dell's XPS 1530 is a superb laptop. Available for as low as Rs 55,000 (and up to Rs 85,000 if configured with all the bells and whistles), the XPS 1530 is stylish, fast, and suitably elegant. The best part is, Dell allows customisation of the processor, memory, graphics solution, and hard drive, among other variables. Our XPS 1530 came configured with a Core 2 Duo T7300, 2 GB of RAM, and an 8600GT graphics solution, along with a 160 GB 7200 rpm hard drive and a 9-cell battery that was good for 3 hours. All this for Rs 68,000—a real contender for the prize!

The Award Dell XPS 1530; HP DV6226tx

The XPS 1530 oozes style, finish, and build quality, and blazing performance at an excellent price point to boot. The only issue we can see with Dell is the availability and presence in our markets. HP has a solid presence in India, with service outlets everywhere, and you can pick an HP notebook off a shelf, while with Dell, you need to order online, and there are delivery times among other inconveniences involved. Unfortunately HP hasn't really upgraded the specs of the DV6xxx series so its one for the Dell.

So we're at an impasse... we



HP DV6226tx

have a better, faster product that needs a better dealer network to become a truly great and hassle-free deal. We're awarding a joint winner here—no runners up; Dell's XPS 1530 and HP's DV6226tx share our Zero 1 award.



Dell XPS 1530

Two excellent products—one brilliant product from a brand that needs more market presence in India, and the other a good product that could use a few upgrades under the hood from a tried and tested brand and a major player in the Indian market.

VALUE LAPTOPS UP TO RS 45,000

The Reigning Champion Compaq Presario v3225AU

The value market for laptops mostly consists of students and executives who either can't really afford to spend more, or simply won't because they don't really need all that performance. This doesn't make the entry-level category any less exciting, since manufacturers have less of a budget to play around with—and this ensures they try really hard to match value with performance. This is by far the most fiercely-competed market segment. The Compaq Presario v3225AU exemplifies value with a nice balance of performance and looks.

The Contenders Dell Inspiron 1520

Dell's Inspiron 1520 rears its head to strike at the v3225AU. It's got a faster processor and more memory, and is infinitely more configurable. The only minus is that it's not ready off the shelf like Compaq is. Of course, it's costlier too, but that's due to the faster components. Another minus for the Dell would be its bland exteriors—there's nothing bland about the



Compaq Presario v3225AU.

The Award Compaq Presario v3225AU

We feel a terrific package for the value audience should have strong roots in, well, value. The Compaq v3225AU brings strong value to the entry-level segment. It sports the high-gloss finish and the kind of design that HP has



brought to their entire line-up. The Zero1 for this year's Value Laptop segment belongs to the Compaq v3225AU.

ULTRA-PORTABLE LAPTOPS

The Reigning Champion Sony Vaio SZ483N/C

Ultra-compacts are rare beasts—and even more rarely sought-after because of the high price associated with fitting high-performance components into a cramped space. Sony's SZ483N/C was an excellent performer, built from a carbon fibre like material, which made the laptop extremely light, and a white LED display that made viewing anything a pleasure, not to mention slimming down what was already a very compact laptop. It was power-



ful, too, with a Core 2 Duo T7400 and a GeForce 7400GO with 2 GB of RAM. The fact that you can switch between an Intel X3000 and the NVIDIA graphics solution for battery life or power usage is another plus.

The Contender Sony Vaio VGN-SZ58GN/C; Dell XPS 1300

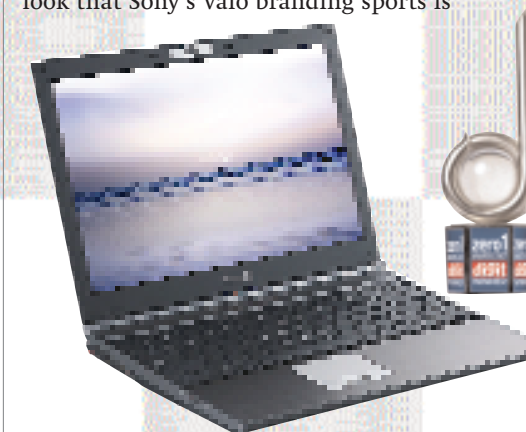
The Sony SZ483N/C has been replaced by a more powerful model, priced identically. That one features a lightning fast T7700 Core 2 Duo processor and a GeForce 8400GS, and is called the Vaio VGN-SZ58GN/C.

Dell's new XPS 1330 is a serious contender to the throne for the most compact yet powerful package. It sports a T7500 and 2 GB of RAM, a GeForce 8400GS graphics card, and a 160 GB, 7200 rpm drive. Serious horsepower for something with a 13.3 inch screen, and enough juice for even moderate gaming! Of course, the portability is further enhanced with the option of a crisp, WLED display that is even slimmer.

Although the XPS 1330 is a good looking piece of hardware, the Vaio SZ483N/C is absolutely gorgeous—and you have to see it in the skin to believe that a laptop could look so absolutely up-market.

The Award Sony Vaio VGN-SZ58GN/C

The Sony Vaio VGN-SZ58GN/C is more than a match for the XPS 1330. Also, the build and look that Sony's Vaio branding sports is



something that Dell's XPS series can only dream of. We're awarding our Zero1 to the Sony Vaio VGN-SZ58GN/C.